



Racking their brains: A comprehensive discussion on various challenges affecting sports in Punjab, including coaching resources and access to infrastructure, involved notable individuals (L-R) such as former India hockey player Rajinder Singh, Asian Games medallist in shooting Avneet Kaur Sidhu, coach and former hockey player Sarpal Singh, Commonwealth Games silver medallist shooter Anjum Moudgill, and Sarvjit Singh, Special Chief Secretary of Sports. **R. V. MOORTHY**

Fuelling India's sporting dreams

Punjab has seen quite a lot of positive development over the years in the promotion of sports but there remain quite a few obstacles to overcome to fully unlock its potential.

"As far as performance and facilities go, the sport has evolved a lot. But as a sportsperson, I feel with a little help from the administration, a lot more can be done," said Avneet Kaur Sidhu, Asian Games medallist in shooting, while speaking on 'Punjab Fuelling India's Sporting Dreams' at the Sportstar 'Focus Punjab' Sports Conclave here.

"The Punjab government has tried to improve infrastructure facilities but there are a lot of things left to be done. We have to see if its proper utilisation is being done or not," Rajinder Singh, former Indian hockey player and coach, said.

"The main issue is the calibre of the coaching education. I think we have not put our work in this direction. We have to put our efforts toward this issue, providing them with opportunities for advanced training, so that Punjab and Indian hockey will develop," he added.

Saravjit Singh, Special Chief Secretary, Sports explained that the government is doing its best in ensuring that the best coaches are available to train aspiring athletes.

"We are working in the right earnest in this direction and the government is alive to the need. We had only 300-350 coaches. That number went up eight times

straight away," he said.

"We have made a simple five-step process to select a coach where physical fitness is a core part so that they can inspire the next generation. The written examination will only be secondary," he added.

Rajinder Singh, who began his tryst with coaching in 2001, explained the need to arrive at solutions for the issues existing in the system with an example. "I noticed that there is only one representative from Punjab in the Indian women's hockey team. This is an area I thought we needed to focus on and we have started two residential centres for the girls," he said.

"We are working for Punjab. If hockey develops in Punjab, it will develop in India. Punjab hockey is the backbone of India," he added.

Commonwealth Games silver medallist and Olympian Anjum Moudgil also echoed similar comments. "I have been representing Punjab since 2017. I have seen quite a bit of positive change since then," she said.

Dronacharya Awardee and veteran hockey player and coach Sarpal Singh also gave his insights.

"We have the talent in our country to do a commendable job if we work together. Many academies have opened, many coaches have been appointed and we are taking care of things like nutrition more carefully," he said. "We have very good football, tennis and hockey potential. I am hopeful that we will achieve good results for both the boys and girls," the 93-year-old added.